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Theme_01_Chip_To_Rack

So what: three differently-named factors found the same four companies, because the value in AI compute has migrated from the accelerator into the cabinet around it

THEME 01 BRIEF

The unit of sale in AI compute is no longer a chip. It is a coherent rack costing \$5m-\$8.8m, and the cabinet's bill of materials has re-weighted away from compute: NVIDIA's own compute share of Data Center revenue fell from 91.5% to 82.4% in four quarters while networking grew 263% year over year, and platform revenue per gigawatt moved from roughly \$18bn to \$40bn. The force is that re-weighting, and it runs on three separate mechanisms that this workbook happened to research under three different names.

Mechanism one — the buyer changed, not the winner. Custom silicon finds that ASIC servers reach 27.8% of AI server shipments in 2026 against a total forecast raised to ~31% growth: a re-mix of a growing market rather than a share war. The economics are gated by a ~\$725m 2nm design programme that breaks even in the low tens of thousands of units — a rounding error for a gigawatt-scale buyer and impossible for anyone else. The money accrues to the enabling layers billed per DESIGN and per unit: design services, connectivity content per XPU, packaging, HBM.

Mechanism two — the content, not the assembly. Rack-scale finds the same thing from the other end: the theme pays whoever supplies what goes inside the cabinet — power, cooling, optics, copper, switch silicon — and taxes whoever merely assembles it. Most of the money this theme moves sits outside the accelerator vendors entirely and is indifferent to which architecture wins.

Mechanism three — where the margin still is. Operating leverage supplies the screen: the expansion that made NVIDIA's earnings was a one-time spreading of a fixed cost base over violently growing revenue, and the remaining money sits with suppliers who still hold that unspent gap — Credo near a 34% opex ratio, Astera Labs in the mid-30s — rather than with names that have closed it. Broadcom's semiconductor arm already runs opex at 6% of segment revenue, below NVIDIA's 9.5%.

Where NVIDIA sits. Inside the theme as its largest single beneficiary and its largest single hostage: it captures the rack today, but the content layer gets paid whether it keeps it or not.

Theme 01 Companies

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Astera Labs	ALAB	emerging	Connectivity silicon attaches to every custom XPU; content per accelerator has gone from below \$100 at IPO to close to \$1,000 per XPU, with a design partnership with Alchip for hyperscaler ASIC racks.	benefits	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Broadcom	AVGO	incumbent	Designs the custom XPU for Google, Meta and OpenAI and sells the SerDes, Ethernet switching and optics around it; AI semiconductor revenue \$10.8B in Q2 FY26, +143% YoY.	mixed	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Celestica	CLS	adjacent	Builds the custom AI/ML rack systems hyperscalers deploy, indifferent to whose silicon is inside; CCS revenue \$3,241.0M in Q1 2026, +76%, with three customers at 35%, 15% and 15% of total revenue.	mixed	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Credo Technology	CRDO	emerging	Active electrical cables and SerDes inside hyperscaler AI racks — the copper interconnect a custom-ASIC rack needs when it cannot use the incumbent's proprietary fabric; Q1 FY27 revenue \$479.0M, +114.7% YoY.	benefits	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Arista Networks	ANET	incumbent	Builds the scale-out and scale-across Ethernet that connects racks into clusters and clusters into campuses; levered to the rack COUNT, not to whose rack.	mixed	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Coherent	COHR	incumbent	Supplies the optics the fabric runs on: 800G and 1.6T transceivers, and in co-packaged optics the laser, ELM, isolators, PM fibre and silicon-photonics PICs rather than one component.	benefits	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Hon Hai Precision (Foxconn)	2317.TW	adjacent	Assembles the rack (est. 40-70% of GB200/GB300 rack assembly in 2025), but NVIDIA shipping pre-assembled trays turns it from system designer into integrator - AI mix rose past 50% of revenue as gross margin fell.	mixed	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
AMD	AMD	incumbent	The merchant second source bidding for the same hyperscaler diversification budget the in-house ASICs take: Instinct at roughly 5-7% of accelerator revenue against custom silicon's 10-15%.	mixed	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Alchip Technologies	3661.TW	incumbent	Pure-play ASIC design house on the AWS Trainium programme and an NVLink Fusion custom-silicon partner; Q1 2026 revenue \$132.4M against \$318.7M a year earlier, 21% of it on 3nm/2nm nodes.	mixed	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon, fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Amphenol	APH	incumbent	Content per rack across high-speed copper, backplane and cable assemblies, fibre connectors, power interconnect and liquid-cooling connectors - bought whatever the architecture.	benefits	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In
Cisco Systems	CSCO	adjacent	A 25% operating margin recovered from 19%, without the revenue growth rate that makes opex spreading possible - the negative control.	mixed	high	fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Eaton	ETN	incumbent	Grid-to-rack electrical: an 800V DC reference architecture with NVIDIA, a sidecar rated to 900kW per rack, and liquid-to-liquid CDUs after the Boyd Thermal acquisition.	benefits	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In
Marvell Technology	MRVL	incumbent	Second custom-XPU house; supplies Google inference accelerators, NICs and memory-interface controllers — data centre was \$2.172B, 79% of Q2 FY27 revenue, +46% YoY.	benefits	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
Quanta Computer	2382.TW	adjacent	Second-source AI rack ODM: servers 80% of Q1 2026 revenue, AI 75% of that, at a 4.78% gross margin - levered to rack volume with almost no claim on rack value.	mixed	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
TSMC	TSM	adjacent	Fabricates and packages both sides of the argument; CoWoS capacity expanding from ~80,000 to 120,000-130,000 WPM through 2026, of which NVIDIA takes ~60% — every custom programme is another claim on the same line.	benefits	high	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
Vertiv Holdings	VRT	incumbent	Supplies the cabinet's power and thermal half - 800V DC sidecar conversion that frees 8-16U for compute, CDUs and direct-to-chip liquid cooling, co-designed into NVIDIA reference platforms.	benefits	high	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In
Ayar Labs		emerging	Package-level optical I/O (TeraPHY) that would let a scale-up domain span a row over fibre, dissolving the copper reach limit that makes the cabinet an indivisible purchase.	benefits	medium	fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In
Cerebras Systems	CBRS	emerging	Wafer-scale alternative that needs neither an HBM stack nor a CoWoS interposer: 900,000 AI cores and 44GB on-die SRAM on one device, with an OpenAI agreement for 750 MW; IPO'd May 2026 raising \$5.55B.	mixed	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
CoreWeave	CRWV	adjacent	Revenue surged while losses widened: the cost of serving growth sits in depreciation and interest, not in spreadable opex.	hurt	medium	fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Fabrinet	FN	adjacent	FY2026 revenue up 36% to \$4.6B with non-GAAP EPS growing faster than revenue - real leverage, capped by a contract-manufacturing gross margin.	benefits	medium	fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent
Global Unichip (GUC)	3443.TW	incumbent	TSMC-affiliated design-service house taking cloud-provider ASIC and CPU programmes; TTM revenue about \$1.17B with North American cloud the dominant end market.	benefits	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
MediaTek	2454.TW	incumbent	Entering custom AI ASIC from mobile SoC — 70+ tape-outs from 7nm to 2nm, production-ready 224G SerDes, first AI accelerator ASIC targeted at mass production in Q4 2026 — but a \$3.5B NVIDIA investment keeps that XPU inside NVIDIA's rack.	mixed	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
SK hynix	000660.KS	adjacent	Sells the HBM stack into a custom ASIC exactly as into a merchant GPU; projected at roughly 70% of the HBM4 segment against accelerator BOM memory lines of \$2,400-\$6,500 per unit.	benefits	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon

The two claims a skeptic would attack, and what stands behind each

THEME 01 EVIDENCE

"Three factors converging is coincidence, not evidence." The three runs were executed independently and could not read each other's output, yet all three landed on Astera Labs, Broadcom, Credo and Celestica. More telling than the overlap is that they reached them by different routes: custom-silicon enablement, rack content and unspent operating leverage. A company that qualifies on all three tests is not a coincidence of screening; it is a company sitting where the theme's money actually lands.

"The top rows are just the obvious AI names." They are not, and the ordering shows it. Celestica is adjacent in two member factors and incumbent in the third — and the rack-scale ideas carries the reason: Dell'Oro has it leading Ethernet AI back-end switch sales in 2Q 2026, ahead of NVIDIA, with Arista third, in the quarter back-end switch spend first overtook front-end. It trades near 16.7x forward against Arista at ~48x. Broadcom is the other case: it appears in five of this workbook's eight researched factors, and its direction flips by lens — benefits under custom silicon and rack content, mixed under operating leverage, because its semiconductor arm already runs opex at 6% of segment revenue, below NVIDIA's 9.5%.

What is NOT established here. Neither member factor measured the margin the content layer actually earns on rack attach. The theme establishes where the revenue moves, not how profitable it is at the destination.

Theme_02_Reported_Numbers_And_The_Multiple

So what: two factors that share only three companies are nonetheless one question read twice — what the reported number means, and what the market will pay for it

THEME 02 BRIEF

This is the weakest join of the four on landscape overlap, and it is kept because the two factors are two halves of a single chain rather than two views of one landscape. Say the chain out loud: a multiple is a number divided by an earnings figure. One factor interrogates the numerator, the other the denominator, and neither is safe on its own.

The numerator — duration, not quality. Price and terminal value finds that in the AI complex the forward multiple is a forecast of WHEN growth fades rather than a score for quality delivered. With roughly 71.6% of modelled enterprise value sitting past the forecast window, and a discount rate now endogenous to the theme (about a third of hyperscaler capex debt-funded in 2026, peaking near 35% in 2027), the return is decided by where a company's value sits in time and how much premium it has to lose. The toll booths paid on gross capex and the zero-premium names carry this very differently from the 70x challengers.

The denominator — the earnings number is part portfolio. Earnings quality finds that ASU 2016-01 / ASC 321 routes unrealised gains on equity stakes straight through net income, and that for private holdings the measurement alternative books the whole step-up at once when someone else's funding round reprices them. At eleven large companies the trailing multiple is therefore taken off a number that is part operating business and part venture book — Alphabet at roughly 78% of H1 2026 profit, Nebius at more than 100% of a quarter's.

Why they are one force. A multiple applied to a distorted earnings base compounds both errors in the same direction, and both resolve on the same kind of event: a quarter in which the marks stop repeating is also the quarter in which the fade becomes observable. The three companies the two factors share — Amazon, Broadcom and Nebius — are exactly the names where both halves bite at once.

Where NVIDIA sits. On both sides: the workbook's own model puts 71.6% of its base-case enterprise value in terminal value, and roughly 17% of its trailing net income is unrealised marks on stakes in its own customers.

Theme 02 Companies

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Amazon.com	AMZN	incumbent	Trailing-four-quarter capex now 102% of trailing-four-quarter operating cash flow, and the highest duration weight in the US investment-grade index - the depreciation wall and the rate channel on one balance sheet.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet, fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Broadcom	AVGO	incumbent	Trades at a ~50% higher forward multiple than NVIDIA while selling the custom ASICs that cause the fade (\$20bn+ AI ASIC revenue in FY2025) - earnings hedged against the theme, multiple not.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet, fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Nebius Group	NBIS	emerging	A ~28% ClickHouse stake revalued on a round that moved ClickHouse from \$6.4B to \$15B produced a \$781M non-cash gain in Q1 2026 - larger than the \$621M of consolidated net income for the quarter.	mixed	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book, fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
ASML Holding	ASML	adjacent	Sole supplier of EUV lithography at \$200M-\$400M per tool, sold on multi-year order books that sit inside the explicit forecast window - structurally the lowest terminal-value share in the chain.	benefits	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Advanced Micro Devices	AMD	incumbent	Carries the complex's largest de-rating cushion: ~70x forward earnings against NVIDIA's ~24x on an AI business roughly 11x smaller, so an in-line quarter is punishing rather than fine.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Alphabet	GOOGL	incumbent	Venture/strategic book (GV, CapitalG, SpaceX, Anthropic) marked through Other Income: ~\$135.9B of H1 2026 unrealised equity gains inside \$135.7B of Other Income against \$174.6B of H1 net income.	benefits	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Berkshire Hathaway	BRK.B	incumbent	Equity-portfolio marks run through net income: a \$22.8B GAAP net loss in 2022 against record \$30.8B operating earnings, and \$16.08B of investment gains inside \$25.67B of Q2 2026 net income.	mixed	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Cincinnati Financial	CINF	adjacent	Listed-equity portfolio marked through net income: Q2 2026 net income \$1,255M vs non-GAAP operating income \$224M, the gap an \$882M after-tax fair-value increase; Q1 2026 ran the other way.	mixed	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Intel	INTC	adjacent	The complex's control case: a designated 'have-not' granted no AI terminal-value premium at all, so a sector-wide de-rating takes almost nothing from its multiple.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Markel Group	MKL	adjacent	Insurance plus a Berkshire-style equity portfolio: Q2 2026 operating income \$1.6B vs adjusted operating income \$436M once investment marks are stripped.	mixed	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Meta Platforms	META	incumbent	Funds the build with the largest investment-grade bond deal of 2025 (\$30bn) plus a ~\$27bn off-balance-sheet SPV - the accounting expression of the theme, keeping capex off the P&L until depreciation catches up.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Micron Technology	MU	incumbent	Memory and packaging are now 60-70% of AI accelerator COGS, and fiscal Q3 2026 GAAP gross margin was 84.6% - quality delivered far above the multiple memory is historically granted.	mixed	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Microsoft	MSFT	incumbent	Equity-method OpenAI stake swung net income -\$3.1B (-\$0.41 EPS) in FY26 Q1 and +\$7.6B (+\$1.02 EPS) in FY26 Q2 on the OpenAI recapitalisation; MSFT now publishes a measure excluding it.	mixed	high	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Taiwan Semiconductor Manufacturing	TSM	adjacent	Manufactures the silicon for every contestant and is paid on wafers and CoWoS packaging regardless of architecture; CoWoS capacity goes from ~80,000 to 120,000-130,000 wafers/month through 2026 with NVIDIA taking ~60% of allocation.	benefits	high	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
CoreWeave	CRWV	emerging	Pure-play AI cloud whose GPU fleet is funded by debt and equity issuance while losses widen - essentially all equity value is terminal, so it re-prices on the discount rate before it re-prices on demand.	hurt	medium	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Oracle	ORCL	incumbent	Debt-funded datacentre buildout whose equity already moves with Treasury yields rather than with bookings - the cost-of-capital channel of this theme biting a large-cap before the earnings channel does.	hurt	medium	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Prosus	PRX	incumbent	Holding company whose reported earnings are an equity-accounted Tencent stake plus a consolidated ecosystem; publishes core headline earnings (+24% EPS FY2026) precisely to separate the two.	mixed	medium	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
SoftBank Group	9984.T	incumbent	The marks ARE the P&L: Vision Fund fair-value changes drive group net income, NAV ~\$472B at 30 Jun 2026 (Arm plus a large unlisted OpenAI stake), shares at roughly a 34% discount to NAV.	mixed	medium	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Tencent Holdings	0700.HK	incumbent	~RMB 903.07B portfolio at 30 Jun 2026, down from RMB 957.22B; listed investee fair value fell RMB 547.1B to RMB 487.2B in Q2 while non-IFRS profit ROSE 10% to RMB 136.32B - the theme in reverse.	hurt	medium	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Nscale		emerging	Private neocloud built on NVIDIA capacity that cannot raise at scale against its own credit - the archetype of the buyer whose financing has to be volunteered by an investment-grade balance sheet.	hurt	low	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet

This is the weakest landscape join in the report, and the case for keeping it is structural rather than statistical

THEME 02 EVIDENCE

"Three shared companies is not a cluster." Correct, and it is why this theme is argued from the chain rather than the overlap. The numerator half and the denominator half are two operations on one ratio. Amazon, Broadcom and Nebius are where both bite simultaneously — and Nebius is the extreme case, with marks exceeding 100% of a quarter's profit while also carrying the duration problem as a challenger multiple.

"The accounting point is an accusation dressed as analysis." It is not, and the member factor is explicit about it: disclosure is complete, and the distortion is a MEASUREMENT effect created by ASU 2016-01 routing unrealised equity gains through net income. The consequence is comparability, not propriety — every ratio built on net income is flattered in the same direction until the marks stop repeating. The who-wins-and-loses read sorts on that basis: vehicles the market already discounts versus ones where the mark is being paid for at face value.

What is NOT established here. No peer's terminal-value share of enterprise value was measured, and no current forward multiple was established for several of the challenger names. The theme's direction is grounded; its magnitudes at the peer level are not.

Theme_03_Underwritten_Demand

So what: the AI buildout is underwritten rather than funded, and the two factors that found this describe the same instrument from the borrower's side and the supplier's side

THEME 03 BRIEF

Six of the eighteen companies here appear in both member factors — CoreWeave, Nebius, Applied Digital, TeraWulf, Blackstone and Digital Realty — which is the strongest landscape overlap in this report. The reason is that both factors are looking at one structure: AI infrastructure demand has moved out of operating cash flow and into credit.

The borrower's side. Credit-funded demand finds hyperscaler capex has outrun operating cash flow (Amazon at 102% of trailing operating cash flow; \$433.9bn of PP&E against roughly \$149bn of depreciation), that roughly a third of 2026 capex is debt-financed, and that below the hyperscalers what actually gets underwritten is the CONTRACT rather than the hardware. The money accrues to whoever arranges, prices or collateralises that credit; the cost lands on whoever pledged a depreciating chip against a five-year loan backed by a three-year contract. The bill arrives at the 2027 refinancing window, not at any collapse in demand.

The supplier's side. Vendor financing finds the same structure written as six distinguishable instruments — residual-value guaranty, revenue floor, capacity purchase commitment, warrant, equity investment, take-or-pay with revenue share — whose common function is to substitute an investment-grade signature for an unratable buyer's. Value moves to whoever RECEIVES the instrument and cost to whoever must WRITE it, and it is invisible on every income statement until a rating method or a refused extension makes it visible.

The finding that widens the theme. It is not chip-vendor-specific. The fringe rows show Cipher Mining's Barber Lake is bankable because GOOGLE backstops up to \$1.73bn of Fluidstack's lease obligations and takes a warrant for it. Any screen built only on chip vendors misses half of this.

The historical anchor. Drivers and horizon sets it against the 2000-01 telecom cycle: roughly \$25.6bn of combined vendor-financing exposure across nine suppliers, Lucent at ~\$8.1bn committed and ~\$3.5bn of provisions, bad-loan ratios moving 2.6% → 60% at Lucent and 25.5% → 80% at Nortel inside a year — with the honest differentiator that the racks are used on day one where the fibre sat dark.

Where NVIDIA sits. As the largest single writer of these instruments: roughly \$99bn of marked stakes plus a \$105bn capped guaranty.

Theme 03 Companies

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Applied Digital	APLD	emerging	Levered landlord to a levered tenant: ~\$36bn of contracted lease revenue with nearly 86% from two customers, ~\$11bn of it CoreWeave, at ~4.8x debt/equity.	mixed	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
CoreWeave	CRWV	incumbent	Borrows against the GPUs themselves: delayed-draw term loans collateralised by NVIDIA hardware, written against customer contracts averaging roughly three years while the paper runs five to six.	mixed	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Nebius Group	NBIS	emerging	Funds GPUs with unsecured converts and customer prepayments instead of GPU-secured debt: \$5.0bn priced August 2026 (0.50% due 2030, 4.50% due 2034), net cash positive.	mixed	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
TeraWulf	WULF	emerging	Imports the credit its tenants lack: a 20-year Anthropic lease worth ~\$19bn (up to ~\$33bn with extensions) plus \$600m of Google credit support standing behind Fluidstack's lease obligations.	mixed	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Blackstone	BX	incumbent	Largest owner of data-centre assets (~\$185bn including QTS) and a lender across the capital stack; QTS raised a \$3.25bn leveraged loan in July 2026.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Digital Realty	DLR	incumbent	The investment-grade landlord that borrows cheaply because its tenants are rated: record \$1.9bn annualised backlog, net debt/EBITDA 4.7x, H2 2026 issuance guided at 4.5-5.5%.	mixed	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded, fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Advanced Micro Devices	AMD	incumbent	Runs the same playbook one tier down and pays in warrants because it cannot pay in cash: up to 14 GW announced across OpenAI, Meta and Anthropic against \$67.2B of equity, where a Piketon-sized guaranty would be 156% of that equity.	mixed	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Ares Management	ARES	incumbent	Arranges the infrastructure debt and keeps a slice: \$2.4bn facility to Vantage holding ~\$1.6bn, against a portfolio where ~99% of North American customers are investment grade.	benefits	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
CME Group	CME	adjacent	Toll booth on the theme's price risk: lists Silicon Data H100 and B200 Rental Index Futures on 5 October 2026, earning fees whether compute rental prices rise or fall.	benefits	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
Cipher Mining	CIFR	emerging	Barber Lake is bankable because Google backstops up to \$1.73Bn of Fluidstack's obligations on a 300 MW, 10-year lease carrying ~\$3.8Bn of contracted revenue — with a concurrent warrant to the guarantor.	benefits	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Core Scientific	CORZ	emerging	Granted AMD warrants over up to 30M shares at \$23.47 as consideration for 529 MW of 15-year leases projected above \$14B of base contracted revenue, expandable to 2.5 GW.	benefits	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
IREN Limited	IREN	emerging	Issued the chip vendor a five-year right to buy 30M ordinary shares at \$70 — up to \$2.1B of potential investment — as the alignment behind deploying up to 5 GW of DSX-aligned AI infrastructure.	benefits	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Oracle	ORCL	incumbent	The most levered investment-grade buyer: FY2026 free cash flow of ~\$23.7bn, debt about 2.5x sales, ~\$260bn of leases not yet commenced, downgraded to the lowest IG rating on AI spending.	hurt	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
SB Energy		adjacent	Lessor at the PORTS Technology Campus, receiving capped credit support of up to \$105B on land, power and shell for roughly 4.25 GW of IT load let to OpenAI on 20-year leases. Private.	benefits	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Apollo Global Management	APO	incumbent	Structures the jumbo private investment-grade placements the public market will not absorb: led a ~\$35bn post-IPO debt financing for Broadcom's AI platform supporting Anthropic compute.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Blue Owl Capital	OWL	incumbent	Converts hyperscaler capex into an asset it owns and leases back: 80% of the ~\$27bn Meta Hyperion JV, the largest private-credit transaction on record.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
Equinix	EQIX	adjacent	Securitises the lease rather than the GPU: a GBP 280m CMBS backed by leases to three investment-grade tenants at 130bp over Gilts, plus a \$3bn IG bond in July 2026.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
S&P Global	SPGI	adjacent	Its guarantee-adjustment method decides whether the layer stays off balance sheet: a guaranty can create a substantial debt-equivalent adjustment at the vendor even where lenders give the borrower no extra collateral value.	mixed	medium	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop

Why these are one structure, and why the strongest rows are on the receiving side

THEME 03 EVIDENCE

"Two factors, one structure — prove it." Six of eighteen companies appear in both, the highest overlap in this report: CoreWeave, Nebius, Applied Digital, TeraWulf, Blackstone and Digital Realty. They are the names that appear in the credit-funded table as borrowers or landlords and in the vendor-financing table as recipients of an instrument. One structure, two vantage points.

"Vendor financing is a 1999 analogy, not an analysis." The historical section carries the magnitudes rather than the vibe — roughly \$25.6bn of combined exposure across nine suppliers at end-2000, Lucent at ~\$8.1bn committed and ~\$3.5bn of provisions, bad-loan ratios moving 2.6% → 60% at Lucent and 25.5% → 80% at Nortel within a year — and it states the disanalogy plainly: the racks are used on day one where the fibre sat dark. That is a bounded comparison, not a prediction.

"This is about chip vendors." The single most useful finding in this theme says otherwise: Cipher Mining's Barber Lake is bankable because Google backstops up to \$1.73bn of Fluidstack's lease obligations and takes a warrant for it. The instrument is the theme; the writer's identity is not.

What is NOT established here — and it cuts one way. Both member factors reported that their benefits-side rows are better evidenced than their hurt-side rows, because a beneficiary's instrument appears in an 8-K with a strike price while the cost to the writer appears in nobody's filing. The table therefore flatters the benign reading, and Digital Realty's hurt grade in one member factor is explicitly labelled inference.

Theme_04_Operator_Premium_No_Exit

So what: this theme rests on ONE factor, and it is kept separate because seven of its twelve companies appear nowhere else in this workbook

THEME 04 BRIEF

The clustering rule for this report is peer-list overlap, and a theme carrying a single factor is usually that factor's research under a new name. This one is the exception the rule allows: its landscape genuinely stands apart. Tesla, Palantir, Shopify, Airbnb, Figma, Apple and Arm appear in no other researched factor — they are governance cases, not AI-infrastructure suppliers, and folding them into a supply-chain theme would bury them.

The mechanism. The founder premium establishes that it is the only large equity premium legally attached to an individual rather than to an asset, a contract or a patent — and that it runs on a governance instrument rather than on charisma. Super-voting stock decouples control from economics so completely that the board cannot fire the founder and, more to the point, cannot compel him to prepare a replacement. Meta runs roughly 61% of the vote on about 13% of the economics; Shopify's non-transferable founder share fixes Lutke at 40% of total voting power even if his economic stake falls to 1.1%.

What it is worth. An equal-weighted strategy long founder-CEO firms from 1993 to 2002 earned a benchmark-adjusted 8.3% a year. Over the decade to 2026, founder-run companies returned about 25% a year against the S&P 500's 14%, and founder-led names averaged 15.4% a year against 6.9% for companies whose founder-CEO had left.

The two clocks. Drivers and horizon is the timing problem: the premium accrues over a ten- to twenty-year tenure and is repriced on a single press release, so the size of the step is set almost entirely by how much was planned in advance. 2024-26 turned this from hypothetical into a calendar — Apple's dated, internally-staffed handover as the template, Intel's four permanent CEOs in seven years as the counter-template, and Broadcom terming Hock Tan out to 2030 as a new pricing convention.

Where NVIDIA sits. On the open-ended side, with an unusually strong record attached: execution grades Diamond on every observable, and succession is the one intrinsic risk left standing.

A single-factor theme has to justify itself twice: that it is separate, and that it is real

THEME 04 EVIDENCE

"One factor is not a theme." The test this report applies is landscape separation, and it passes on the numbers: seven of the twelve companies — Tesla, Palantir, Shopify, Airbnb, Figma, Apple and Arm — appear in no other researched factor in this workbook. The five that do overlap (Broadcom, CoreWeave, Intel, Meta, Marvell) are cited for governance reasons here and for supply-chain or valuation reasons elsewhere, which is coincidence of name rather than of force.

"Founder premium is a story, not a mechanism." The mechanism section grounds it in instruments that are written down: super-voting structures with stated ratios, named successors or their documented absence, and disclosed ownership thresholds. The premium is measured (8.3% benchmark-adjusted annually, 1993-2002; 25% a year against the S&P's 14% over the decade to 2026) and so is the gap after a founder leaves (15.4% versus 6.9%). That is a screen off filings, not a personality read.

"The names are cherry-picked to make the point." The table deliberately carries both outcomes: Apple as an executed, dated handover; Marvell as a founder-impaired asset turned around after Starboard took roughly 7%; Intel as serial succession failure with four permanent CEOs in seven years. The ideas treat Intel as standing evidence that the turnaround setup fails at least as often as it works.

What is NOT established here. No quantified step size for an UNPLANNED exit at mega-cap scale. Every magnitude above is either a long-run return differential or a planned transition; the theme's central claim — that an unplanned exit reprices in one step — has no clean event study behind it in this corpus. That is the most valuable unfinished work in this theme.

Theme 04 Companies

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Apple	AAPL	adjacent	Executed the transition: Cook to executive chairman and Terner to CEO effective 1 September 2026, announced four months ahead from a 25-year internal candidate after a stated long-term succession process.	benefits	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Broadcom	AVGO	incumbent	Operator premium without a founder: the board extended Hock Tan to 2030 and tied a stock award worth roughly US\$616.6m at the 300% level to reaching US\$120bn of AI product sales by that year.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Figma	FIG	emerging	Listed July 2025 with the mechanism re-armed: Field controls 73.6% of the vote on ~8.9% of the economics via 15-vote Class B plus an irrevocable proxy over co-founder Wallace's shares.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Intel	INTC	adjacent	Serial succession failure with no founder premium left to lose: Gelsinger stepped down as CEO and from the board on 1 December 2024 with no successor ready, three months of interim co-CEOs followed, and Lip-Bu Tan became the fourth permanent CEO in seven years.	hurt	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Marvell Technology	MRVL	adjacent	Founder-impaired asset turned round by professional management: Sutardja and Dai were ousted in April 2016 after Starboard took roughly a 7% stake, and Matt Murphy rebuilt the company around data-infrastructure silicon.	benefits	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Meta Platforms	META	incumbent	Ten-vote Class B gives Zuckerberg ~61% of the vote on ~13% of the economics, so no board majority can compel a transition plan it is not offered.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Palantir	PLTR	incumbent	Class F stock plus the Founder Voting Agreement lets the founders control up to 49.999999% of total voting power, over a government/defense franchise whose counterparty relationships are personally held by Karp.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Shopify	SHOP	incumbent	A non-transferable founder share fixes Lutke at 40% of total voting power for as long as he serves in any capacity, even if his economic stake falls to 1.1%.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Tesla	TSLA	incumbent	Product roadmap, capital allocation and the equity narrative all run through one founder-CEO who also runs SpaceX, xAI and X; no formal succession plan has been published and the 10-K names him personally as a dependency.	mixed	high	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Airbnb	ABNB	incumbent	Three founders hold roughly 80% of the voting power on about 27% of the economics through 20-vote Class B; Chesky alone commands about 32% of the vote.	mixed	medium	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession
Arm Holdings	ARM	adjacent	Segars-to-Haas succession executed cleanly in 2022, then partly undone: in April 2026 Haas took an expanded SoftBank International role while remaining Arm CEO, re-concentrating key-man exposure in one person across two entities.	mixed	medium	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
CoreWeave	CRWV	emerging	Went public in 2025 with founder control preserved through a Class B share class carrying stronger voting rights than the Class A sold to outside investors; the three 2017 founders remain the key control bloc of an AI-infrastructure business barely a year listed.	mixed	medium	fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession

Summary

So what: eight factor-research runs describe four forces, and the two that matter most for money both point away from the accelerator

THEMES SUMMARY

Eight promoted factors were researched independently, producing 83 peer rows over 53 distinct companies. Clustered on peer-list overlap — the one piece of evidence the workers could not have coordinated on — they resolve into four forces covering all 100 points of the factor set's composition weight. Nothing is unclustered.

1. VALUE MIGRATES FROM THE CHIP TO THE RACK — WEIGHT 42/100

Members: fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon (w20), fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In (w17), fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent (w5).

Companies: 23 — 11 incumbent / 4 emerging / 8 adjacent; 12 benefits / 10 mixed / 1 hurt.

The cabinet's bill of materials re-weighted away from compute, and three differently-named factors independently found the same four companies sitting where the money went. The content layer is paid per unit regardless of which architecture wins; the assembler is taxed. This is the largest force in the set and the one furthest from the accelerator.

2. REPORTED NUMBERS STOP MEANING WHAT THE MULTIPLE ASSUMES — WEIGHT 30/100

Members: fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet (w21), fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book (w9).

Companies: 20 — 12 incumbent / 3 emerging / 5 adjacent; 3 benefits / 13 mixed / 4 hurt.

The weakest landscape join and the one kept on structure rather than overlap: a multiple is a number over an earnings figure, and these two factors interrogate opposite halves of that ratio. Both errors compound in the same direction, and both resolve on the same kind of quarter.

3. AI DEMAND IS UNDERWRITTEN, NOT FUNDED — WEIGHT 20/100

Members: fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded (w13), fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop (w7).

Companies: 18 — 8 incumbent / 6 emerging / 4 adjacent; 10 benefits / 7 mixed / 1 hurt.

The strongest landscape overlap in the report — six of eighteen companies in both members. Demand is underwritten rather than funded, so value moves to whoever arranges or receives the credit instrument and cost to whoever writes it. The 2000-01 telecom vendor-financing cycle is carried as a bounded comparison, disanalogy stated.

4. THE OPERATOR PREMIUM WITH NO EXIT PLAN — WEIGHT 8/100

Members: fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession (w8).

Companies: 12 — 6 incumbent / 2 emerging / 4 adjacent; 2 benefits / 9 mixed / 1 hurt.

A single-factor theme, kept because seven of its twelve companies appear in no other factor. The founder premium is the only large equity premium legally attached to a person, which makes it screenable off filings: dated handovers are paid, open-ended control is charged.

UNCLUSTERED

None. All eight researched factors found a home, which is itself worth noting — it says the factor set was coherent rather than a collection of unrelated observations. The nearest thing to an outlier is The operator premium with no exit plan, which carries one factor and is justified in its brief on landscape separation.

WHAT THIS REPORT DOES NOT SETTLE

- **Confidence grades are lopsided in three of four themes, and always in the same direction.** Theme 1, 2 and 3 all have better evidence on the benefiting side than the losing side. The member runs diagnosed the cause consistently: a beneficiary's exposure appears in an 8-K with a figure attached, while the cost to the squeezed party appears in nobody's filing. Theme 4 is the exception — its single hurt row is high-confidence.
- **Roughly half the peer-company sources failed ingestion** (Cloudflare/Akamai blocks and crawler timeouts on investor-relations pages). Several peer rows therefore carry reported financials attributed in prose rather than quoted from a document in this workbook. The exposure LINKS are documented; some of the numbers are not.
- **No theme measured the profitability of the destination.** Each establishes where revenue or value moves, not what margin it earns on arrival — most sharply in theme 1, where the rack-attach margin is the obvious next question.
- **The web-search budget was exhausted mid-run** (a soft budget of 150, ending above 440 across concurrent runs), so the fringe screens for emerging entrants were capped. That is the most valuable unfinished work across all four themes.

One line per researched factor, and which theme claimed it

MEMBER FACTORS

- **fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon** — zone external, weight 20. Custom AI silicon pays the enablers rather than the contestants: the durable money is in design services, connectivity content per XPU, packaging and HBM — layers billed per accelerator DESIGN and per unit rather than per winner — while the clearest loser is not the market leader but the merchant second source bidding for the same diversification budget. → claimed by **Value migrates from the chip to the rack.**
- **fc_07 Rack-Scale Platform Lock-In** — zone ecosystem, weight 17. The rack shift pays whoever supplies what goes inside the cabinet - power, cooling, optics, copper and switch silicon - and taxes whoever merely assembles it, so most of the money this theme moves sits outside the accelerator vendors and is indifferent to which architecture wins. → claimed by **Value migrates from the chip to the rack.**
- **fc_11 Operating Leverage Already Spent** — zone intrinsic, weight 5. The margin expansion that made NVIDIA's earnings is a one-time spreading of a fixed cost base, and the money in the theme now sits with companies still holding that unspent gap - Credo near a 34% opex ratio and Astera Labs in the mid-30s - not with the names that have already closed it, of which Broadcom's 6%-of-segment-revenue semiconductor arm is further along than NVIDIA itself. → claimed by **Value migrates from the chip to the rack.**

- **fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet** — zone external, weight 21. In the AI complex the forward multiple is a forecast of when growth fades rather than a score for quality delivered, so money is made or lost on where a company's value sits in time and how much premium it has to lose - which means the toll booths paid on gross capex and the zero-premium names carry this theme very differently from the 70x challengers and the debt-funded builders. → claimed by **Reported numbers stop meaning what the multiple assumes**.
- **fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book** — zone intrinsic, weight 9. An accounting rule pushes unrealised gains on private stakes straight into net income, so at eleven large companies - Alphabet at ~78% of H1 2026 profit, Nebius at more than 100% of a quarter's - the trailing multiple is being taken off a number that is part operating business and part venture portfolio; the money is in owning the force through vehicles the market already discounts, and in the first quarter the marks do not repeat. → claimed by **Reported numbers stop meaning what the multiple assumes**.
- **fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded** — zone external, weight 13. AI infrastructure demand is now underwritten in the credit markets rather than paid for out of cash flow, so the money accrues to whoever arranges, prices or collateralises that credit - arrangers like Ares and Blue Owl, investment-grade landlords like Digital Realty, and venues like CME - and the cost lands on whoever pledged a depreciating chip against a five-year loan backed by a three-year contract, with the bill arriving at the 2027 refinancing window rather than at any collapse in demand. → claimed by **AI demand is underwritten, not funded**.
- **fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop** — zone ecosystem, weight 7. Vendor financing moves the money to whoever RECEIVES the instrument — credit-enhanced landlords, underwritten neoclouds and the fee layer assembling third-party pools — and takes it from whoever must WRITE it with a smaller balance sheet; the cost is invisible on every income statement until a rating method or a refused extension makes it visible. → claimed by **AI demand is underwritten, not funded**.
- **fc_09 Founder-Led Execution, Unplanned Succession** — zone intrinsic, weight 8. The founder premium is the only large equity premium legally attached to a person rather than to an asset, so it screens off public filings: the theme pays the companies that have dated the handover and charges the ones whose super-voting control has removed the board's ability to make one. → claimed by **The operator premium with no exit plan**.

No researched factor is unclustered.

Superseded Collision Residue

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Oracle	ORCL	incumbent	The most levered investment-grade buyer: FY2026 free cash flow of ~\$23.7bn, debt about 2.5x sales, ~\$260bn of leases not yet commenced, downgraded to the lowest IG rating on AI spending.	hurt	high	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
SB Energy	TSM	adjacent	Lessor at the PORTS Technology Campus, receiving capped credit support of up to \$105B on land, power and shell for roughly 4.25 GW of IT load let to OpenAI on 20-year leases. Private.	benefits	high	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Apollo Global Management	APO	incumbent	Structures the jumbo private investment-grade placements the public market will not absorb: led a ~\$35bn post-IPO debt financing for Broadcom's AI platform supporting Anthropic compute.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
Blue Owl Capital	OWL	incumbent	Converts hyperscaler capex into an asset it owns and leases back: 80% of the ~\$27bn Meta Hyperion JV, the largest private-credit transaction on record.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
Equinix	EQIX	adjacent	Securitises the lease rather than the GPU: a GBP 280m CMBS backed by leases to three investment-grade tenants at 130bp over Gilts, plus a \$3bn IG bond in July 2026.	benefits	medium	fc_05 Demand Is Credit-Funded
S&P Global	SPGI	adjacent	Its guarantee-adjustment method decides whether the layer stays off balance sheet: a guaranty can create a substantial debt-equivalent adjustment at the vendor even where lenders give the borrower no extra collateral value.	mixed	medium	fc_08 Self-Funded Demand Loop
Tencent Holdings	0700.HK	incumbent	~RMB 903.07B portfolio at 30 Jun 2026, down from RMB 957.22B; listed investee fair value fell RMB 547.1B to RMB 487.2B in Q2 while non-IFRS profit ROSE 10% to RMB 136.32B - the theme in reverse.	hurt	medium	fc_10 Earnings Quality and the Investment Book
Nscale	FN	emerging	Private neocloud built on NVIDIA capacity that cannot raise at scale against its own credit - the archetype of the buyer whose financing has to be volunteered by an investment-grade balance sheet.	hurt	low	fc_06 Price, Terminal Value and the Guidance Bet
Global Unichip (GUC)	3443.TW	incumbent	TSMC-affiliated design-service house taking cloud-provider ASIC and CPU programmes; TTM revenue about \$1.17B with North American cloud the dominant end market.	benefits	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon

COMPANY	TICKER	ROLE	EXPOSURE	DIRECTION	CONFIDENCE	SOURCE_FAC...
MediaTek	2454.TW	incumbent	Entering custom AI ASIC from mobile SoC — 70+ tape-outs from 7nm to 2nm, production-ready 224G SerDes, first AI accelerator ASIC targeted at mass production in Q4 2026 — but a \$3.5B NVIDIA investment keeps that XPU inside NVIDIA's rack.	mixed	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon
SK hynix	000660.KS	adjacent	Sells the HBM stack into a custom ASIC exactly as into a merchant GPU; projected at roughly 70% of the HBM4 segment against accelerator BOM memory lines of \$2,400-\$6,500 per unit.	benefits	medium	fc_01 Share Ceded to Custom Silicon